



DESIGN NOTE

Officer and Soldier Leadership Development

TWO-PAGE AITC DISCUSSION PIECE: DESIGN DRAFT

New Zealand Army Leadership Centre | Army Command School

Reference: NZDF Leadership Framework v2 (Oct 2025); LDS, Leadership Levels and Leadership Framework posters · **Date:** September 2026 · **Status:** Design draft for approval

1. The Tasking, Reduced to Its Point

COMDT ACS asked ACS (ALC) to table a discussion piece at the AITC before end of year on how the Officer and Other Rank promotion continuums align with the intent and design of the LDF: present the facts and challenge the organisation to decide about the development of leaders at all levels. The trigger was a request to link Lead Leaders to promotion to substantive Captain.

Read against that, the issue is narrow:

Army applies a deliberate link between leadership development and promotion within the Soldier continuum. The equivalent relationship within the Officer continuum is less clear. Is this difference deliberate, and if so, why?

The earlier seven-page construct tested six categories at six transitions for two continuums. That was a diagnostic of the whole system. COMDT is asking a sharper question, so the product is reduced to two pages and the six-category matrix is withdrawn from the briefing product.

2. The Two Pages

Page	Purpose	What is on it
1. Two continuums. One leadership framework.	Show the asymmetry	One visual. The LDF's seven levels as the spine. Officer continuum on the left, Soldier continuum on the right, each showing rank, the development intervention at that point, and whether it is mandated. Headline question above; the question for Army beneath.
2. The discrepancy	Let the answer emerge, then pose the challenge	Two flows with identical steps. Soldier: promotion point, mandated development, development completed, promotion: a deliberate link. Officer: promotion point, development exists, not mandated?, promotion: an unclear link. Then: is this difference a conscious choice? If so, what is the rationale? If not, should Army apply a more consistent principle?

The three wordings are fixed:

Place	Wording
Headline, page 1	How deliberately does Army link leadership development to progression through its Officer and Soldier promotion continuums?
Question, foot of page 1	If Army deliberately mandates leadership development for soldiers as they progress through increased leadership responsibility, why is the same principle not applied consistently to officers?
Challenge, page 2	Is this difference a conscious choice? If so, what is the rationale for treating Officer and Soldier leadership development differently? If not, should Army apply a more consistent principle to development before progression into increased leadership responsibility?

3. Why the LDF Stays in the Middle

The LDF is retained as the spine because it is the common reference that makes the comparison fair. Its levels describe progressively different leadership requirements: a genuine shift from effective individual contribution, to getting things done through others, through other leaders, to running a system, building capability, integrating at enterprise level, and stewarding the institution. Placing the two continuums against it allows one question to be asked at each transition: at the same developmental shift, what does Army require of a soldier, and what does it require of an officer?

Two points from the sources still govern how the spine is used.

1. **The rank mapping is an estimate.** The Leadership Levels poster says its alignment of rank to level is "only an estimation". Rank pairings on page 1 place the comparison; they do not assert that a rank equals a level. The page says so in one line.
2. **The LDS intends development before the transition.** The Leadership Development System places the LDS course in the Orientation phase, ideally about six months before the first posting to the new level. Whether Army's promotion courses achieve that for either continuum is part of what the facts must show.

4. What Is Known and What Is Not

Populated cells on page 1 are limited to what the four sources and the NZALC course data sheets support, and every one is tagged TO CONFIRM until checked against SOLO and promotion policy.

Transition	Soldier	Officer
T1 Lead Self to Lead Teams	A1530 JNCO Course includes ELDA Lead Teams (A18011) and LDS Lead Teams (D03020)	Commissioning course; whether LDS Lead Teams is embedded is unknown
T2 Lead Teams to Lead Leaders	A1531 SNCO Course; ELDA Lead Leaders (A18008); LDS Lead Leaders (D03030) prerequisite	ELDA Lead Leaders targets 2LT and LT; the link to substantive CAPT is the live request
T3 Lead Leaders to Lead Systems	A1532 WO Course; ELDA Lead Systems (A18010)	ELDA Lead Systems targets CAPT preparing for MAJ; A1302 Staff and Tactics referenced
T4 to T6	LDS courses delivered by ILD; Army practice unknown	LDS courses delivered by ILD; Army practice unknown

The facts still required are the same three for every transition on each side, and are listed in the accompanying register:

1. **Promotion point.** The authoritative Army promotion or career point that corresponds to the transition.
2. **Development intervention.** The course or programme that develops the individual for that transition, with its SOLO code.
3. **Mandate.** Whether that development is a prerequisite for promotion, embedded in the promotion course, expected but not mandatory, or unconnected.

The most important single fact is the Officer answer to item 3 at T2 and T3, because that is where the asymmetry is expected to show and where the substantive Captain request sits.

5. Tone

The piece does not set out to prove the Officer system wrong. COMDT's posture is the intellectual stance: are we consciously choosing to deviate from best practice, and if so, why? There may be a defensible reason for treating Officer development differently. The job of the two pages is to expose the difference clearly enough that Army has to articulate that reason, or decide to change. Both branches of the closing question are given equal weight, and no recommendation is attached.

6. What Has Been Withdrawn

The six-category matrix (rank, appointment, development, career linkage, timing, assurance), the gap taxonomy, and the seven-page sequence remain in the repository history as analytical scaffolding. They are not part of the briefing product. If AITC asks for the fuller diagnostic after the discussion, they can be revived from the retained data register without redesign.